

1999 A tsunami causes extensive damage.

2003 Economic reforms take Vanuatu off the international blacklist of tax havens.

2009 Prime minister Edward Natapei is temporarily removed from office after missing three sittings of parliament without submitting written explanation.

2010 Natapei is ousted following a vote of no-confidence. He is replaced by his deputy Sato Kilman.

«216–17 Polynesian Expansion

Tuvalu



One of the world's smallest and most isolated states, Tuvalu consists of nine atolls.

1892 Britain annexes the Ellice Islands.

1916 The Ellice Islands are joined to the Gilbert Islands.

1974 Ellice Islanders vote to separate from the Gilberts.

1978 Independence from the UK as Tuvalu.

1987 Tuvalu Trust Fund is set up to provide future income for the islands.

1998 Lucrative deal for the sale of the country's ".tv" internet suffix.

2000 Joins UN as the 189th member.

2001 New Zealand agrees to take Tuvalu citizens if the islands, none of which is higher than 15 ft (4.5 m) above sea level, are flooded as a result of global warming.

«216–17 Polynesian Expansion

Samoa



The nine Polynesian volcanic islands of Samoa lie in the heart of the South Pacific.

1830 Colonial rivalry begins for control of the islands. The chiefs of the islands sign treaties with various European powers in 1838–39.

1889 After continuing rivalry between the UK, Germany, and the US for influence, the three powers agree by the Treaty of Berlin to guarantee Samoa's independence and neutrality.

1899 The Samoan Islands are divided between German Western and US Eastern Samoa.

1914 New Zealand troops occupy Western Samoa at the start of World War I. New Zealand remains the colonial power until independence in 1962.

1962 Western Samoa becomes the first independent Polynesian nation.

1990 Cyclone Ofa leaves 10,000 people homeless.

1991 Universal suffrage is introduced: previously, only the 1,800 elected chiefs could vote.

1997 The country's name is changed to the Independent State of Samoa.

2007 King Malietoa Tanumafili dies after ruling Samoa for 45 years.

2009 Samoa switches to driving on the left-hand side of the road. Tsunami kills 200 people.

«216–17 Polynesian Expansion

Fiji



A volcanic archipelago in the south Pacific ripped apart by racial tensions in recent years.

1643 Abel Tasman, the Dutch explorer, sights the Fijian islands.

1800 The first Europeans begin to settle in Fiji: sailors, escaped convicts from Australia, traders, and missionaries.



Island immigrant

Between 1879 and 1916, the British brought in laborers from India to work on the copra and sugar cane plantations. By 1945 Indians like this farmer outnumbered ethnic Melanesian Fijians.

1874 Fiji becomes a British colony.

1937 Fiji's legislative council becomes partly elected, partly nominated.

1970 Independence from the UK.

1987 Election win for Indo-Fijian coalition leads to coups to secure minority ethnic Fijian rule. Fiji becomes a republic and is ejected from Commonwealth.

1989 Mass Indo-Fijian emigration.

1990 Constitution discriminating against Indo-Fijians introduced.

1997 Census shows ethnic Fijians outnumber Indo-Fijians. Fiji rejoins the Commonwealth. New constitution changes the name to the Fiji Islands.

1999 General election won by Labour Party. Mahendra Chaudhry becomes the first Indo-Fijian prime minister.

2000 After a civilian-led coup, a new ethnic Fijian government is formed.

2006 Fiji is suspended from the Commonwealth after another coup.

2009 The Appeal Court rules the suspension was illegal. President Iloilo repeals the constitution, dismisses all judges, appoints himself head of state, and reappoints Frank Bainimarama as prime minister. The Commonwealth imposes full suspension on Fiji.

«216–17 Polynesian Expansion
«282–83 Exploring the Pacific

Tonga



Tonga is unique in the Pacific as it has retained its monarchy and was never colonized.

300 BCE Tonga settled by Polynesians.

1643 Abel Tasman visits the islands, followed by Captain Cook in 1773.

1820 Taufa'ahau Tupou (George I) becomes king of his native Ha'apai and unifies the other islands by 1843.

1860 Tonga becomes Christian.

1862 King grants freedom to the people from the arbitrary rule of minor chiefs.

1875 First constitution is established.

1900 Amid concern over German ambitions in the region, the Treaty of Friendship and Protection is signed with the UK.

1958 Greater autonomy from the UK is enshrined in a Friendship Treaty.

1965 Taufa'ahau Tupou IV accedes on the death of his mother, Salote Tupou III.

1970 Full independence within British Commonwealth.

1996 Limited general election sees strong showing by prodemocracy candidates.

2000 King appoints his conservative third son, 'Ulukalala Lavaka Ata, as prime minister for life, but he resigns in 2006.

2001 The official court jester, a US businessman and financial adviser, loses \$26 million of public money.

2006 Resignation of 'Ulukalala Lavaka Ata, as prime minister. Feleti Sevele becomes the first non-noble prime minister in his place. King Taufa'ahau Tupou IV dies. He is succeeded by Crown Prince Tupouto'. A state of emergency is declared after riots protesting the lack of democracy.

2009 A committee on constitutional reform recommends the institution of a popularly elected parliament and the reduction of the monarchy's role to a ceremonial one.

«216–17 Polynesian Expansion

Antarctica



The world's fifth-largest continent, Antarctica is almost entirely covered with thick ice.

1820 Russian explorer Thaddeus von Bellingshausen is first European to sight Antarctica.

1839–43 British explorer James Clark Ross discovers new territory around what is now called the Ross Sea.

1909 British explorer Ernest Shackleton's expedition gets to within 97 nautical miles (180 km) of the Pole.

1911 Expedition led by Norwegian explorer Roald Amundsen is first to reach the South Pole.

1912 British explorer Robert Scott reaches the South Pole one month after Amundsen; Scott and his team die two months later on the return journey.

1929 US aviator Richard Byrd is the first person to fly over the South Pole.

1957–58 International Geophysical Year launches scientific exploration of Antarctica.

1959 Antarctic Treaty signed by 12 countries: international governance is set up and all seven national territorial claims are frozen.

1978 Convention limiting seal hunting comes into force.

1979 Air New Zealand flight 901 crashes into Mount Erebus. All 257 aboard killed.

1985 Ozone layer depletion above Antarctica is discovered.

1994 Establishment of Antarctic whale sanctuary.

1998 Agreement on 50-year ban on mineral extraction comes into force.

2007 There are currently 46 signatory nations to the Antarctic Treaty, of which 18 have observer status.

«320–21 Completing the Map